

Beyond ‘stuff’: navigating a complicated relationship with consumption

As our awareness of the climate crisis grows, and the problems with mass production of fashion and consumables become more and more visible to us, our relationship with buying things grows ever more complex. Seeing the impact that our purchases are having on the planet imbues our emotional spending complexes with an added layer of shame and guilt, but does it really act as a deterrent for most of us? After all, if being aware of the damaging implications of our actions was all it took to create better habits, financial wellbeing probably wouldn't be such an elusive concept in the first place. Our relationship with consumption is, in many ways, completely broken, and a necessary part of learning to spend mindfully is re-evaluating how we engage and the part that we play. Activist, consultant and author of *Consumed*,¹ Aja Barber, has some thoughts on the main factors that make our relationship with consumption so toxic:

‘Not only is this cycle damaging to ourselves and our wallets, but it's also damaging to the planet. Our way of mass-producing items (whether it be clothing or other material possessions) for rapid consumption is ruining the planet and filling up landfills. The root of the consumption problem is discontent, and I think social media has played a huge part in that, fuelling our need for more, more, more every time we sign on to Instagram or elsewhere. We don't talk about mindfulness enough in our society and figuring out what is “enough”, whether it's clothing